

takes you to a random destination. Google Earth produces a short description of the place along with an image with an option to navigate several identical related places.

Alternatively, you can also download the Google Earth Pro tool and search for locations without navigating to the website. The advantage of using Google Earth Pro is that you can view short tours of satellite images from various places.

<http://dgit.in/goearth>

Advantages

Google Earth is free to use with 3D capability in more than 45 languages. It is also possible to view data historically including the ability to embed the output into web pages.

Quirks

The main demerit is that you need high bandwidth Internet connectivity. It produces low resolution images in few areas and some of the places are not yet covered due to restrictions. You will not find extensive information about less developed countries.

Competitors

NASA WorldWind (<http://dgit.in/nasawind>) is a free virtual globe navigation tool. With the open source API, developers will be able to quickly create visualisations of maps and 3D globes in an interactive way. WorldWind can be used to monitor cities, terrains, weather patterns including the capability to track vehicle movement and much more. However, the tool is slow and doesn't provide exhaustive information like Google Earth.

With **Marble** (<http://dgit.in/marblekde>), you can explore both a virtual globe and a world atlas. You can navigate across the globe, pan around, and measure distances between locations. You can not only search for locations, but also refer to Wikipedia articles about the same. You can create routes by simply by dragging and dropping markers. Street view can be explored with OpenStreetMap, which provides detailed maps with a fluid user interface. It is not possible to access Marble via the web like you can with Google Earth. The installation process for the tool is a bit complicated as compared to WorldWind.

Some of the other competitors to Google Earth are ossimPlanet, Virtual Ocean and GeoMapApp.